

# Who Leaves Teaching, and Why?

## The Anatomy of Teacher Attrition in the United States, 1997–2024

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### Abstract

Every few years the United States rediscovers that teachers quit, and calls it an exodus. This paper builds the longest and deepest anatomy of teacher attrition available from a single instrument: the March Current Population Survey question comparing last year's longest job with this week's occupation, read from the raw Census files at their officially documented positions for twenty-eight consecutive supplements, calendar 1997–2024. The rate of leaving the profession has no trend: it averages 8.6 percent over twenty-eight years, peaked at 10.3 in 2001 and 10.2 in 2019, and stood at 7.7 in 2024. Its anatomy explains why the number is so stable and so misread. Of every 100 leavers, 62 exit the labor force altogether—38 at retirement ages—12 are unemployed the following March, and only 26 hold another job, a third of them still in education and care. Exits barely respond to the business cycle, and where they do, downturns push teachers out; booms do not pull them away. For the minority who do switch careers, the move is a lottery rather than a raise: the median switcher gains 15 log points, but a quarter lose more than 30 and nearly half of all leavers report no earnings at all the next year. What predicts exit is the contract, not the person: part-year work, part-time hours, and missing pension coverage dwarf every demographic; the one personal event that matters is a birth, which raises exit by five points—an effect that is twice as large as in nursing and that has been fading for two decades as the motherhood exit disappears. Meanwhile teaching is the only comparison profession whose attrition *fell* between 2004–2014 and 2015–2025, even as its relative pay slid from 80 to 72 percent of the median college graduate. Teaching does not lose more people than comparable professions; it loses them differently—to retirement systems and to family—and policy aimed at a generic exodus misses both margins.

**JEL codes:** I20, J22, J31, J45, J63. **Keywords:** teacher attrition, occupational mobility, Current Population Survey, public-sector labor markets, teacher pay.

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# 1 Introduction

There is a real tension at the heart of the American conversation about teachers. On one side, the concern is legitimate and well documented: turnover is costly for schools and students (Ronfeldt et al., 2013; Hanushek et al., 2004), staffing is chronically hard in special education, mathematics, and high-poverty schools (Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond, 2017), and teacher pay has fallen visibly behind other college-graduate careers (Allegretto, 2023). On the other side, the flagship statistic of the alarm—“one in six teachers walks away every year”—does not survive contact with its own sources. The 16 percent figure combines two very different behaviors: teachers who move between schools but keep teaching, and teachers who actually leave the profession. The second group, the one the word “exodus” evokes, has been seven to eight percent of the workforce for as long as the data can see, in every dataset that measures it.

This paper documents that fact and everything underneath it, using one instrument pushed as far as it will go. The March Current Population Survey (CPS) asks every household about the *longest job held last calendar year* and about the *occupation this week*. Whoever taught last year and no longer teaches this March has left teaching within a window of at most fifteen months—and the CPS then reports where they landed: another occupation, unemployment, or out of the labor force, together with their earnings before and after. Harris and Adams (2007) introduced this design; Aldeman and Yi (2025) recently used its modern files to make the level; the follow-up surveys of the National Center for Education Statistics (NCES) confirm the same level from school rosters (NCES, 2024). What no one has done is run the instrument at full depth and full length: every supplement from 1998 to 2025, read from the raw fixed-width Census files at the byte positions of the official technical documentation, harmonized into a single person-level database of five million records, validated person-by-person against within-panel classifications, decomposed by route, age, sex, sector, state, and family event, priced by linking consecutive Marches, and modeled with the covariates the ASEC carries. That is the contribution: not a new theory of teacher labor markets, but the longest and most complete measurement of one, with temporal comparison built into every figure.

Five findings organize the paper. *First, the level is flat and always has been.* Leaving teaching averaged 8.6 percent over 1997–2024, with two nearly identical peaks a generation apart (10.3 in 2001, 10.2 in 2019) and no trend in between or since (Figure 2). Covid produced a two-year excursion that fully reversed. *Second, most leaving is not career change.* Of every 100 leavers, 62 exit the labor force—38 of them at ages 55 or older—and only 26 work in another job the following March (Figure 3). The age profile is the classic U: 11 percent of the youngest teachers leave, 4 percent at mid-career, 28 percent at 65–80, and the retirement route accounts for essentially the entire right arm (Figure 4). *Third, the family margin is large, specific, and dying.* A new baby raises a woman’s probability of leaving teaching by 5.9 percentage points, roughly double the effect in nursing and accounting (Figure 6); but the exit-to-home route of young mothers has collapsed from 8–10 percent a year in the late 1990s to under 5 today (Figure 7), and the family share of all exits has shrunk accordingly. *Fourth, exits are weakly counter-cyclical, not pro-cyclical.* Across twenty-eight years the job-switching route is essentially acyclical ( $r = -0.16$  against the unemployment rate at observation), while the withdrawal routes rise mildly in downturns ( $r = +0.29$ ); across states,

every statistically detectable case is of the “recessions push out” variety and none of the “booms pull away” variety (Figures 8 and 9). The story in which a hot labor market lures teachers into better-paid jobs does not appear in the data. *Fifth, pay explains retention patterns better than exit levels.* Leaving for another job is a gamble—median gain 15 log points, fat tails on both sides, 47 percent of all leavers with zero earnings the next year (Figures 10 and 11)—which is exactly why so few take it. Meanwhile teacher pay fell from 80 to 72 percent of the median college graduate over the window, and teaching is nonetheless the only comparison profession whose attrition *declined* between the two halves of the sample (Figures 12 and 14).

The paper is organized around its figures. Section 2 describes the instrument, the pooled database, the definitions that reconcile the numbers in the public debate, and the validation exercises. Sections 3–10 present the anatomy: the changing workforce, the rate, the routes, the family margin, the cycle, pay, the multivariate portrait, and the comparison professions. Section 11 concludes with what the anatomy implies for policy. Appendices carry the instrument audit, the comparison with Harris and Adams (2007), construction details, robustness tables, and additional figures.

## 2 Data and measurement

### 2.1 The March retrospective instrument

The Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC) of the CPS, fielded every March, asks two questions that together identify profession leaving. The first is retrospective: the occupation of the *longest job held during the previous calendar year* (OCCUP). The second is contemporaneous: the occupation of the job held *this week* (PEI00CC), together with the labor force status recode (A\_LFSR), which distinguishes the employed, the unemployed, and those outside the labor force. A *teacher* is a respondent whose longest job last year carried a K–12 teaching occupation code (preschool through secondary and special education, plus the “other teachers” residual; postsecondary teachers, aides, and tutors are excluded). A *leaver* is a teacher who, by the March interview, is not employed in a teaching occupation: either working in some other occupation (*switchers*), unemployed, or out of the labor force. Because status comes from A\_LFSR rather than from the occupation variable—which carries the last job held even for the unemployed—the three routes are mutually exclusive and exhaustive.

Three features of the design matter for interpretation and recur throughout the paper. *Timing:* the supplement of survey year  $t+1$  measures calendar year  $t$ ; the exit itself occurs at some point between the end of the teaching spell in year  $t$  and the March interview—for teachers, typically at the end of a school year. We therefore date exits by the calendar year taught and, where the labor market at the moment of observation matters (Section 7), measure it in the survey month itself. *Leave is not exit:* a teacher on maternity or medical leave in March reports “with a job, not at work,” counts as employed, and—if the job is a teaching job—as a stayer. Our leavers are genuine separations. *Movers are invisible by design:* a teacher who changes school but keeps teaching keeps the occupation code and is a stayer. This is precisely what makes the CPS number a measure of *profession* attrition rather than school turnover.

## 2.2 One pooled database from the raw files

All results come from a single person-level database built from the original Census public-use files: 5,009,129 person-year records across the 28 supplements of survey years 1998–2025, containing 104,545 teacher-year observations (85,497 for college graduates aged 18 and over, the baseline universe). For survey years 2011–2025 the modern machine-readable files are used directly. For survey years 1998–2010 the public files are fixed-width records whose layouts are not machine-readable; every variable was extracted at the byte positions published in the official Census technical documentation (`cpsmar98.pdf`–`cpsmar10.pdf`), so that education, supplement weights, labor force status, demographics, household structure, last-year job characteristics (weeks, hours, class of worker, pension coverage), earnings, and state of residence exist on a common footing in *every* year. Occupation codes are harmonized across the four Census classification regimes with era-consistent code sets. Appendix C documents the construction; Table 3 reports record counts by source. All series are weighted with the ASEC supplement weight unless noted.

## 2.3 What “leaving” means: reconciling the public numbers

The headline numbers in the policy debate are consistent with one another once definitions are aligned; the alarm comes from mixing them. The NCES Teacher Follow-up Survey reports *total turnover* of public school teachers of 13–16 percent across its waves. That total is the sum of two components the survey itself keeps separate: *movers*, who change school but keep teaching (5–8 percent per wave), and *leavers*, who exit the profession (5.6 percent in 1988–89, rising to 7.4–8.4 percent from 2000–01 onward) (NCES, 2024; Tan et al., 2025). Aldeman and Yi’s CPS estimate of roughly 7.6 percent measures leavers only (Aldeman and Yi, 2025), as does Harris and Adams’s 7.7 percent for 1992–2001 (Harris and Adams, 2007), and as does our series, which averages 8.2 percent for college-graduate teachers over 2015–2024 and 8.6 percent over the full window. There is no contradiction anywhere in this literature: school-to-school mobility roughly doubles profession leaving, and only the latter belongs in a sentence containing the word “exodus.” Our estimates sit slightly above the NCES leaver rates for overlapping years, as they should: the CPS covers private school teachers, whose attrition is nearly twice the public rate (Section 5), while the NCES figure is public-only.

## 2.4 Validation

Two audits back the instrument. First, a person-level cross-validation: for respondents observed in the CPS monthly rotation long enough to be classified by a four-month within-panel criterion *and* answering the March retrospective question, the two classifications agree in 99.1 percent of cases ( $n = 9,461$ ; Appendix A, Table 1). Second, a timing audit: the correlation of the leaving series with the national unemployment rate is +0.08 using the year *before* the teaching year, +0.32 using the teaching year itself, and +0.47 using the year the exit is observed—exactly the gradient the retrospective design implies, and



**Figure 1:** The changing profile of the teaching workforce, 2005–2024.

College-graduate teachers aged 18+ whose longest job last year was K–12 teaching; ASEC supplement weights. Thin gray lines are annual values; blue lines are centered 3-year averages, with endpoint values printed. “Public school,” “part-time,” and “pension plan” refer to the longest job held last year; the open circle marks 2013, a year with a reduced sample due to the ASEC redesign. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements, survey years 2006–2025.

evidence that the instrument dates transitions where it claims to. External anchors point the same way: the NCES leaver rates for its five overlapping waves fall within a point of our series.

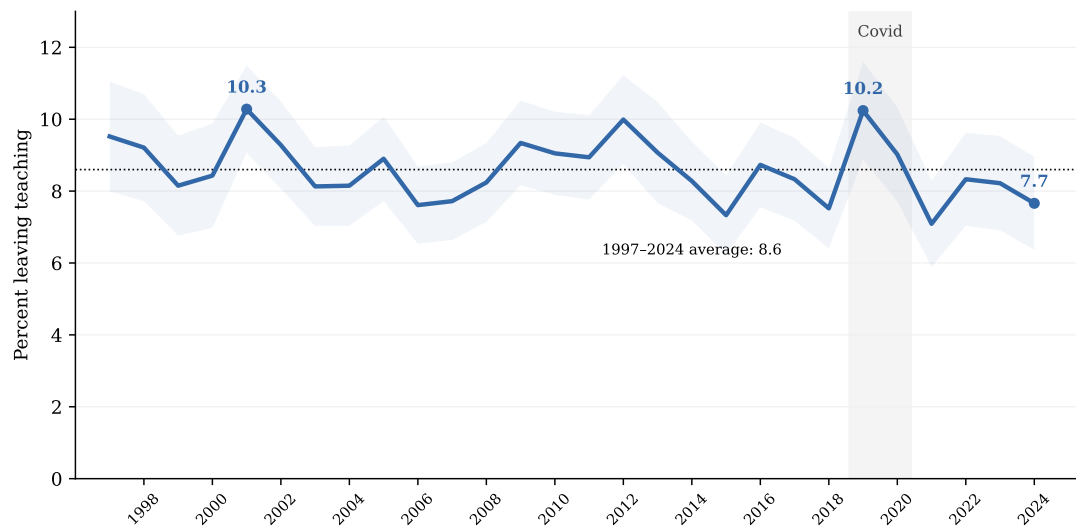
### 3 A changing profession

Figure 1 tracks the composition of the teaching workforce over the last two decades, panel by panel; each panel shows the annual series in light gray and a three-year average in blue. Four slow-moving facts stand out, and each returns later in the paper as a mechanical driver of attrition.

The workforce is aging: mean age rose from 42.8 to 44.8, and the share of teachers aged 55 or more rose with it—which matters because Section 5 shows the 55+ retirement route is the largest single component of attrition. It is increasingly credentialed (45 to 51 percent with a master’s degree or more) and slowly diversifying (8 to 11 percent Black). The share with a young child at home has fallen from 19 to 14 percent, the demographic echo of later and lower fertility—and, as Section 6 shows, the family exit route has fallen even faster than the share of potential mothers. Finally, the employment contract has deteriorated on the one margin the attrition model will single out: pension coverage at the last-year job fell from 80 to 66 percent, the steepest change in any panel.

### 4 The rate: twenty-eight years without a trend

Figure 2 is the paper’s spine: the share of college-graduate teachers who left the profession each calendar year from 1997 to 2024, on one continuous, consistently defined, weighted series—to our knowledge the



**Figure 2: Leaving teaching, 1997–2024.**

Share of college-graduate teachers (longest job last calendar year) not employed in a teaching occupation the following March, by route-based definition; ASEC weights. Shaded band: 95 percent confidence interval using a design factor of 1.5. Dotted line: the 1997–2024 mean (8.6). The gray band marks the Covid supplements. The occupation classification changes between calendar 2001 and 2002 (1990 to 2000 Census codes); a core-codes-only series shows the same profile (Appendix D). Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements, survey years 1998–2025.

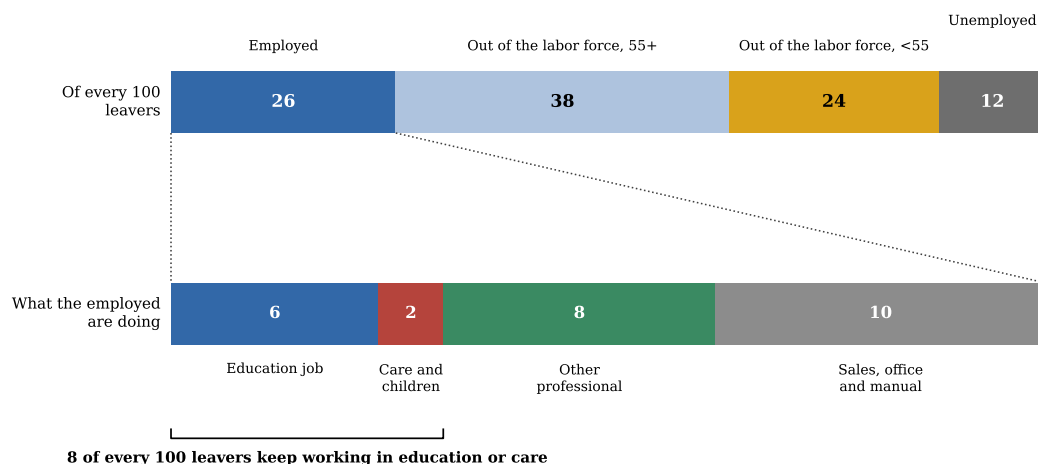
longest ever assembled from this instrument.

Three features deserve emphasis. First, the *level*: 8.6 percent on average, never below 7 and above 10 only three times in twenty-eight years. Second, the *absence of trend*: the two highest points sit eighteen years apart—10.3 in 2001, at the end of the dot-com boom, and 10.2 in 2019, on the eve of the pandemic—and the series ends at 7.7, below its long-run mean. The Covid episode reads as an excursion, not a break: 10.2 in 2019, 9.0 in 2020, 7.1 in 2021, back to trend since. Third, the *framing* this stability invites. An annual outflow of eight percent, composed overwhelmingly—as the next section shows—of retirements, family spells, and early-career sorting, is best understood as the profession’s *natural rate* of attrition: the turnover a five-million-person, majority-female, pension-covered occupation generates in the ordinary course of life-cycle events. Fluctuations around it have never exceeded two points in either direction. Any policy narrative that begins from an accelerating exodus begins from a fact the data do not contain.

## 5 Where leavers go

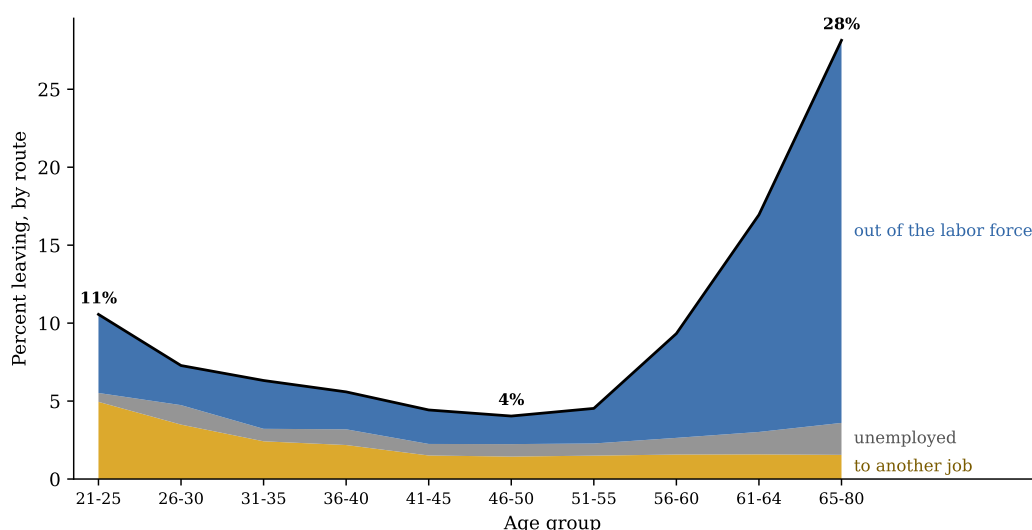
Figure 3 decomposes the flow. Of every 100 college-graduate teachers who leave, 62 are not working the following March: 38 are out of the labor force at ages 55 or older—the retirement route—24 are out of the labor force younger than 55, and 12 are unemployed. Only 26 hold a job. And of those 26, eight remain in education or care work—school administration, counseling, childcare—so that barely one leaver in six represents the scenario the exodus narrative describes: a working-age teacher productively employed outside education a year later.

The age profile in Figure 4 shows where each route lives. Total leaving traces the classic U: 11 percent



**Figure 3:** Of every 100 teachers who leave the profession.

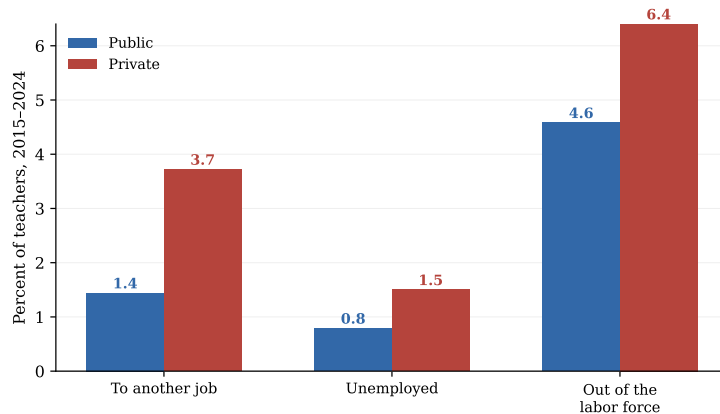
College-graduate leavers pooled over calendar 2015–2024, ASEC weights. Top bar: labor force status the March after the teaching year; “out of the labor force” is split at age 55. Bottom bar: the occupational destination of the 26 employed leavers, rescaled to sum to their total. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.



**Figure 4:** Leaving by age, decomposed by route.

College-graduate teachers pooled over calendar 2015–2024, ASEC weights; ten age groups. The black line is the total leaving rate; stacked areas decompose it into exits to another job (gold), unemployment (gray), and out of the labor force (blue). Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

among teachers aged 21–25, a flat 4–5 percent through ages 41–55, then 9, 17, and 28 percent in the three oldest groups. The decomposition explains both arms. The left arm is career search: nearly half of the exit of the youngest teachers is to another job, a share that decays rapidly with age—and, notably, the early hump is a male phenomenon (15 percent for men aged 21–25 versus 9 for women). The right arm is retirement, almost entirely: from age 55 the out-of-labor-force route accounts for nine tenths of a rapidly rising total, while the job-switching route is flat at 1.5 percent from age 35 to the end. Unemployment never exceeds two percent at any age. Mid-career teachers—the group schools most need to retain and the group the crisis narrative implicitly describes—are the least mobile workers in the figure.



**Figure 5:** Public and private school teachers leave differently.

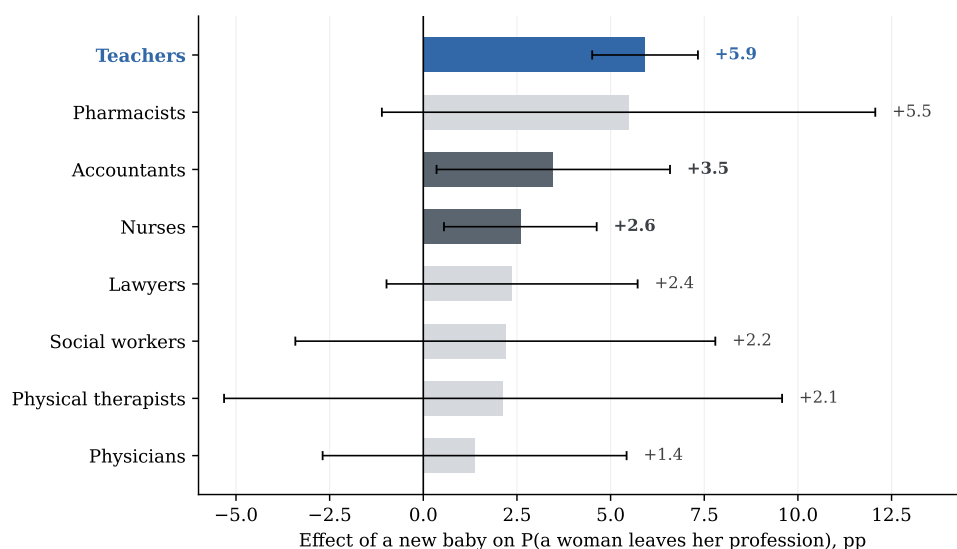
Route-specific annual exit rates of college-graduate teachers by sector of the last-year job (class-of-worker: government vs. private), pooled 2015–2024, ASEC weights. A private-school teacher who moves to a public school—or vice versa—remains a teacher and is not a leaver here. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

One split deserves its own figure. Private school teachers leave the profession at nearly twice the public rate—11.6 versus 6.8 percent a year—and the excess runs through *every* route (Figure 5): to other jobs (3.7 vs. 1.4), to unemployment (1.5 vs. 0.8), and out of the labor force (6.4 vs. 4.6). Because sector switching within teaching does not count as leaving, this is genuine profession attrition, not churn between sectors. The gap is persistent across the whole window and concentrated among the young: a private school loses roughly one in five of its under-30 teachers to the profession every year. The public sector premium in retention—tenure protections, salary schedules, and above all pension coverage—previews the multivariate result of Section 9.

## 6 The family margin, and its slow disappearance

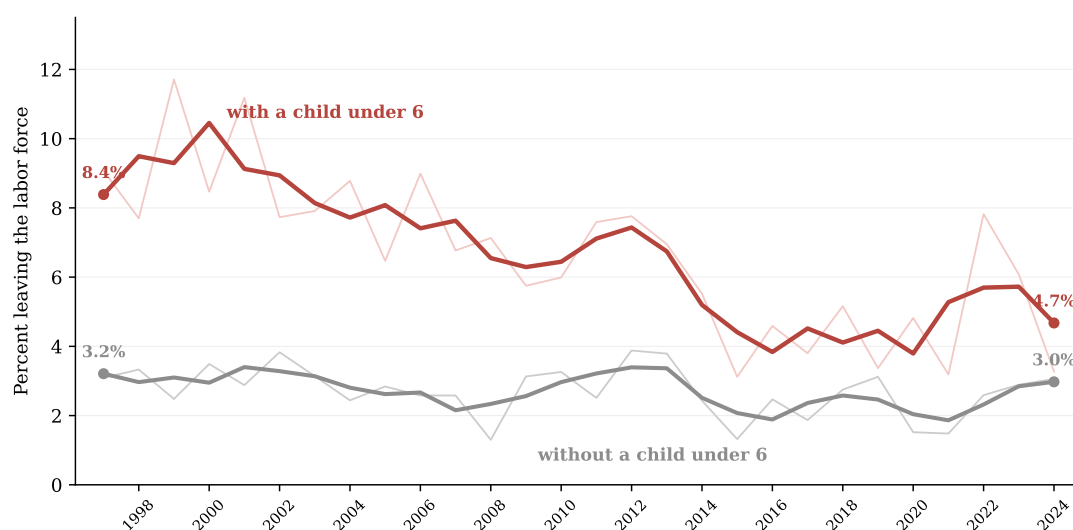
If the contract is the main systematic predictor of exit, the main personal event is a birth. In the pooled model of Section 9, a new baby raises a teacher’s probability of leaving by 4.7 percentage points; among women the effect is 5.9 points. Figure 6 puts that number in comparative perspective: the teaching effect is roughly double the birth-year exit in nursing (2.6) and accounting (3.5), the two comparison professions where the effect is also statistically detectable.

Two readings of this gap coexist, and the data support both. The harsher one is rigidity: teaching offers no part-time ladder, no shift swaps, and no remote option—a teacher either covers her classroom at its hours or does not work—so the arrival of an infant forces a binary choice that nursing, with its shift structure, does not force. The gentler one is Goldin’s (2014) logic of career interruption costs run in reverse: teaching is the college profession where stepping out is *cheapest*—certification persists, seniority premia are flat, jobs exist everywhere—so mothers who in another career would hang on through the infant years can afford to pause. A linked-sample audit supports the second reading as a substantial component: about a third of new-mother leavers are observed teaching again within a year. The birth effect, in other words, is



**Figure 6:** The birth-year exit, teaching versus seven professions.

Average marginal effect of a new baby (own child aged 0 in the household) on the probability that a woman leaves each profession, from profession-specific probits with age, age squared, marital status, education, and year effects; whiskers are 95 percent confidence intervals. Solid bars are significant at 5 percent; light bars are not. Samples pool 2010–2024. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

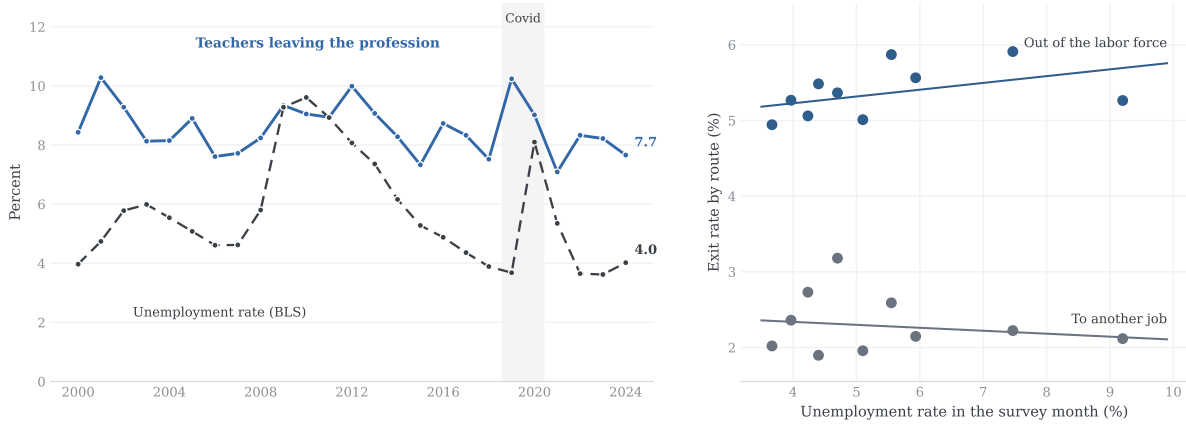


**Figure 7:** The fading motherhood exit, 1997–2024.

Women teachers aged 22–45, college graduates; annual probability of leaving the labor force (thin lines) and centered 3-year averages (bold), separately for those with and without an own child under 6 at home. Endpoint values printed. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements, survey years 1998–2025.

partly a revolving door, not only an exit.

Whatever its interpretation in the cross-section, the margin is disappearing in the time series. Figure 7 tracks the probability that a young woman teacher leaves the labor force, separately for mothers of children under six and for other women. In the late 1990s the gap was five to seven points a year—the classic exit to home. It has narrowed almost continuously for twenty-five years and stands below two points at the end of the window (4.7 versus 3.0 in 2024). Combined with the falling share of teachers who have young



**Figure 8:** Leaving teaching and the labor market, 1997–2024.

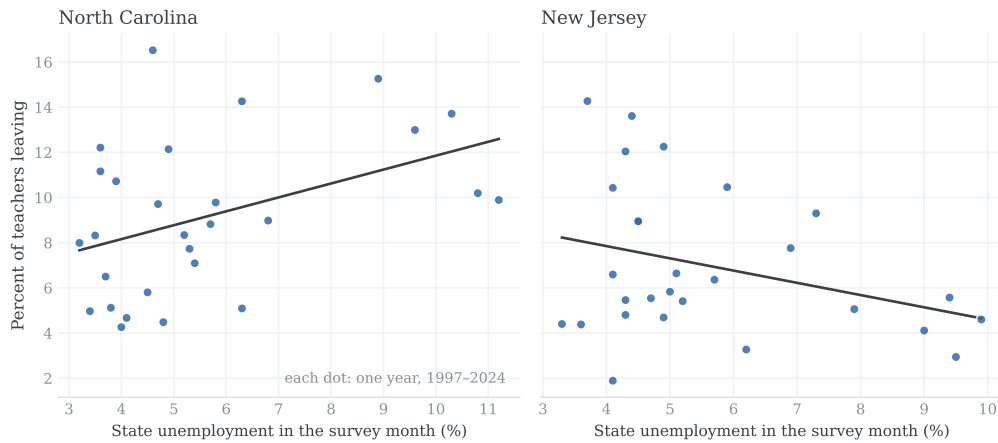
Left: the leaving series of Figure 2 (annual, from calendar 2000) against the BLS national unemployment rate (annual average). Right: binned scatter (deciles of the unemployment rate in the survey month, March of  $t+1$ , when the exit is observed) of the two labor-market routes, with OLS fits on the underlying annual data; correlations are  $-0.16$  (to another job) and  $+0.29$  (out of the labor force). Unemployment: BLS via FRED (UNRATE). Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

children at all (Figure 1), the family route explains a shrinking slice of total attrition—the composition shift visible in Appendix Figure 15. A state-level test of whether paid family leave programs accelerate this decline is underpowered but points the right way: the birth-year exit effect is 2.1 points smaller in state-years with an active program, on only 268 treated births (Appendix E).

## 7 Attrition and the business cycle

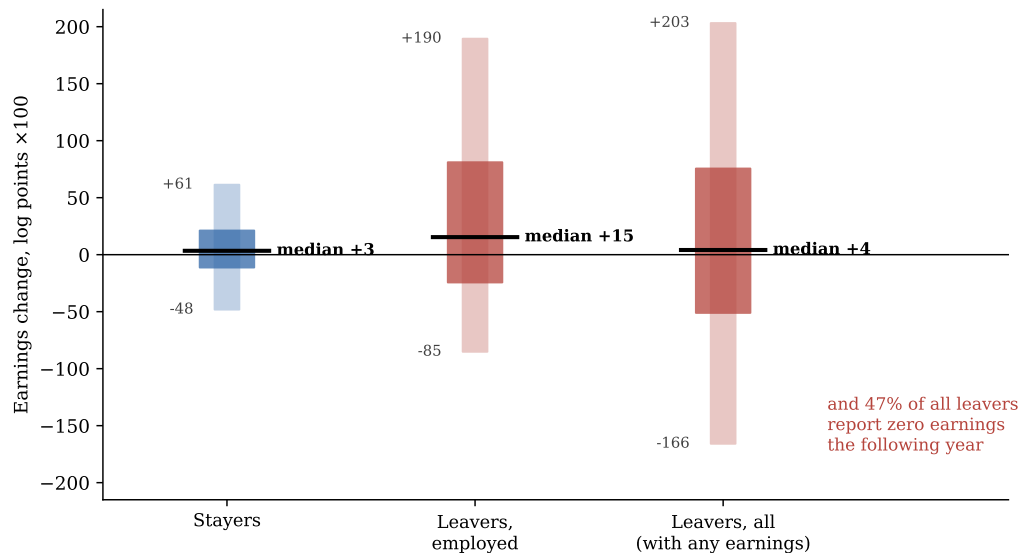
A popular version of the exodus story is cyclical: when the economy booms, outside options improve and teachers are poached. The data say close to the opposite. In levels (Figure 8, left), leaving is a flat line while unemployment swings through three recessions; the two series touch only around Covid. In the cross-section of years (right panel), the job-switching route is essentially acyclical—if anything it *falls* when unemployment is high ( $r = -0.16$ ), as fewer outside offers arrive—while the withdrawal route rises moderately in downturns ( $r = +0.29$ ): slack markets bring forward retirements and returns to home production, an old pattern in female labor supply. The route into unemployment correlates  $+0.55$  with the aggregate rate, a near-mechanical validation of the instrument.

State-level variation sharpens the asymmetry. Estimating the within-state relationship between leaving and the state unemployment rate for all fifty-one jurisdictions over twenty-eight years yields a distribution of slopes centered near zero—in the large states, where power is real, the estimates are tight zeros (California  $+0.21 \pm 0.22$ )—with a telling tail: the only four states where the relationship is statistically distinguishable from zero (Mississippi, Arizona, Maine, Indiana) all lie on the “exits rise in downturns” side, and not one state shows a significant “exits rise in booms” pattern (Appendix Figure 16). Figure 9 illustrates the two signs with one state each. Where teacher exits respond to the cycle at all, recessions push; booms do not pull.



**Figure 9:** Two illustrative states.

Annual state leaving rates of college-graduate teachers (dots; one per year, 1997–2024) against the state unemployment rate in the survey month (BLS Local Area Unemployment Statistics), with OLS fits. North Carolina and New Jersey are shown as *examples* of the two signs; the full 51-state distribution of slopes is in Appendix Figure 16. State of residence is recovered from the household records of the raw files (Appendix C). Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

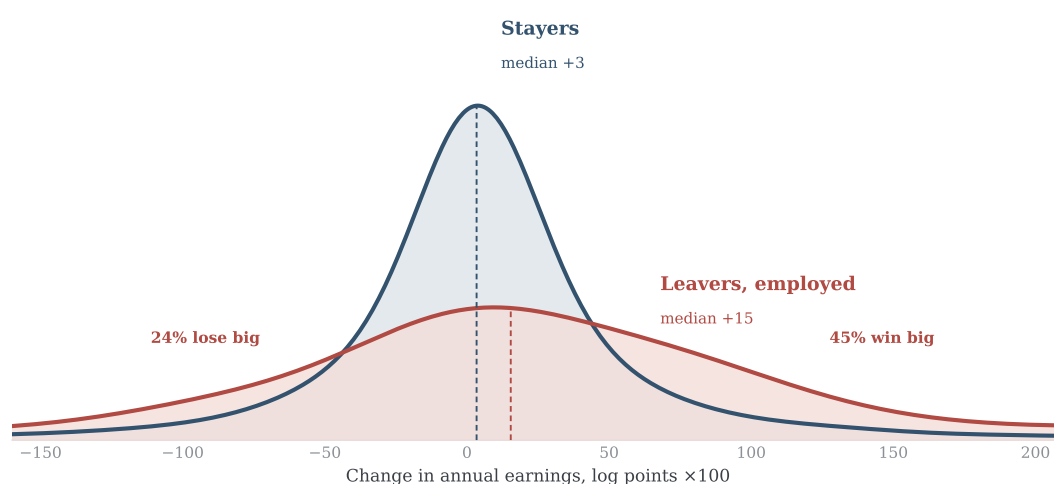


**Figure 10:** The earnings change of leaving, linked March to March.

Person-level change in annual wage and salary earnings between the teaching year and the following year, for teachers linked across consecutive supplements (rotation-group links, survey years 2011–2025; identity validated on sex and age). Boxes: 25th–75th percentiles (dark) and 10th–90th (light); bars mark medians. “Leavers, all” conditions on positive earnings in both years; 47 percent of all leavers report zero earnings the following year and are excluded from the boxes. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

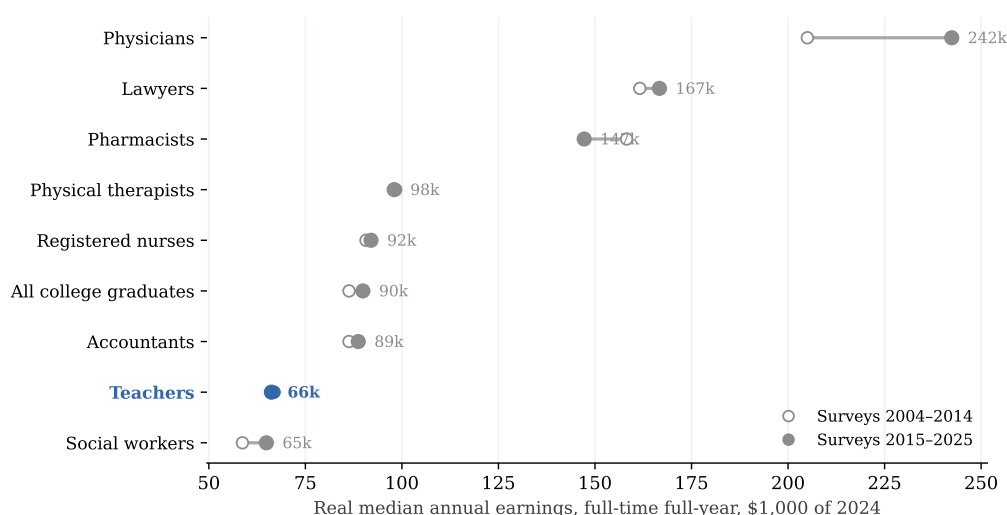
## 8 Pay: the gamble of leaving and the slide of staying

Does leaving pay? The honest answer is: it *can*, and that is different from *does*. Linking teachers across consecutive Marches prices each transition at the person level (Figure 10). Stayers experience ordinary wage growth: a median of +3 log points with a tight distribution. Leavers who land in another job show a median of +15—but around it, dispersion several times the stayers’: the tenth percentile loses 85 log points, the ninetieth gains 190. Figure 11 draws the two distributions: the leaver density is a flattened tent



**Figure 11:** The same distributions, drawn.

Kernel densities of the person-level earnings change (log points  $\times 100$ ) for stayers and for leavers employed the following year; dashed lines mark medians. “Lose big”/“win big” denote changes beyond  $\pm 30$  log points. Densities are estimated on 12,195 stayer and 225 leaver links; bandwidth 0.25. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

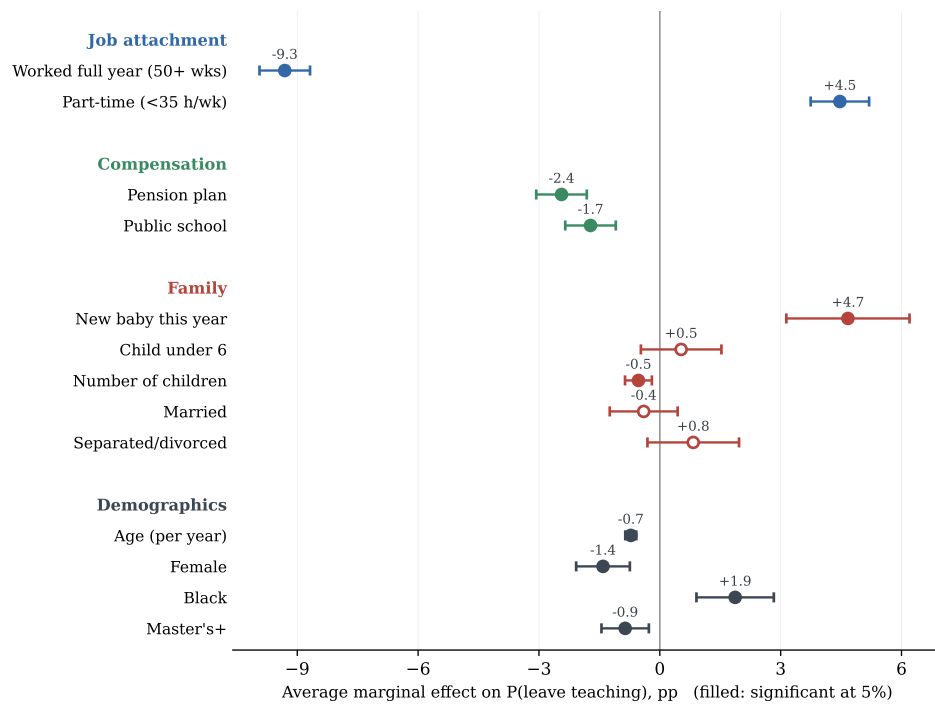


**Figure 12:** Real pay by profession, two symmetric windows.

Weighted median annual wage and salary earnings of full-time, full-year college graduates aged 25–60, in each profession and overall, deflated to 2024 dollars with the CPI-U; the two windows pool survey years 2004–2014 and 2015–2025. Filled dots (with values): recent window. Occupation codes harmonized across classification regimes. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements; CPI: BLS via FRED.

with mass far into both tails—24 percent lose more than 30 log points, 45 percent gain more than 30. And all of this conditions on earning anything at all: 47 percent of leavers report zero wage and salary earnings the following year, consistent with the route decomposition of Figure 3. Leaving teaching for money is a lottery with a modest median prize; the rational response of a risk-averse, pension-covered workforce is to buy few tickets, and that is what Figure 2 shows.

The staying side of the ledger has deteriorated. In real terms, the median full-time, full-year teacher earns \$66,000 (2024 dollars) in the recent decade—essentially unchanged from the decade before—while



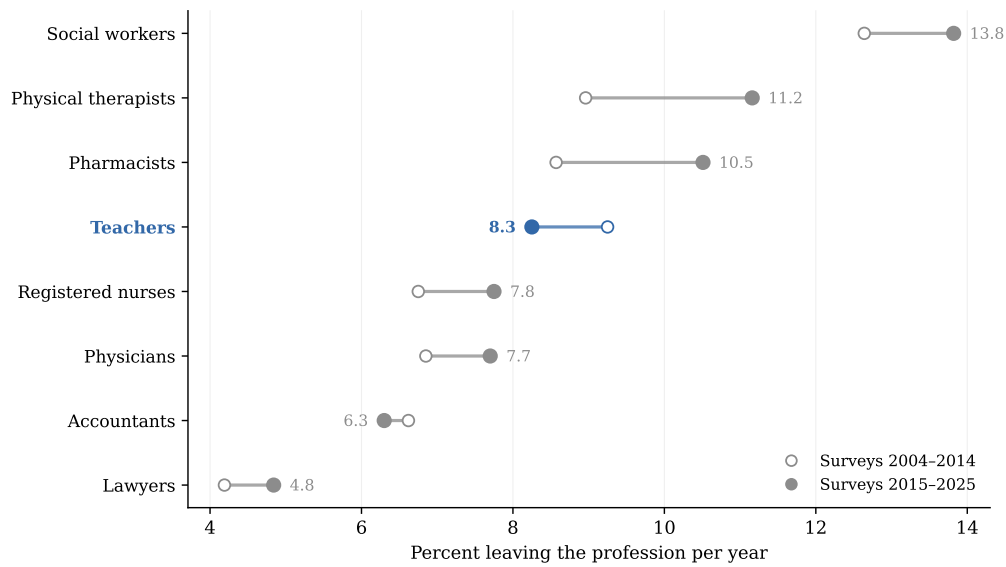
**Figure 13:** Who leaves teaching: probit average marginal effects.

Average marginal effects (percentage points) on the probability of leaving teaching, from a probit on college-graduate teachers pooled over calendar 2015–2024 with year effects; whiskers are 95 percent confidence intervals; filled markers are significant at 5 percent. “Worked full year” is 50+ weeks at the last-year job; “part-time” is under 35 weekly hours.  $n = 28,900$ . Robustness across estimators, weights, fixed effects, windows, and definitions, and subsample estimates, are in Appendix E. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

registered nurses moved to \$92,000, accountants to \$89,000, and the median college graduate to \$90,000 (Figure 12). Indexed to 2002, teacher real pay ends the window six percent *below* its starting point, against +3 for nurses and +8 for accountants (Appendix Figure 18); as a ratio, teacher pay slid from 80 to 72 percent of the median college graduate. This is the CPS version of the teacher pay penalty documented by Allegretto (2023), measured here with one consistent instrument alongside everything else in the paper. The juxtaposition with Section 10 is the point: the profession whose relative pay fell furthest is also the only one whose attrition declined. Pay operates on margins the exit rate hides—who enters, who feels trapped, how retention interacts with pensions—not as a simple valve on the outflow.

## 9 Who leaves: the multivariate portrait

Figure 13 assembles the portrait in one model. The dominant predictors are contractual. A teacher who worked the full year is 9.3 points less likely to leave; part-time hours add 4.5 points; pension coverage subtracts 2.4; a public school subtracts 1.7. Against these, demographics are small: each year of age subtracts 0.7 (the U-shape enters through age squared), women are 1.4 points less likely to leave than men, Black teachers 1.9 more, a master’s degree subtracts 0.9. The family block is a tale of one variable: the number of children and the presence of a child under six do essentially nothing, but the *birth year itself* adds 4.7 points—the event, not the state, drives the exit.



**Figure 14:** Occupational leaving in eight professions, two symmetric windows.

Annual rate of leaving each profession (same route-based definition as for teachers, college graduates, ASEC weights), pooled over survey years 2004–2014 (open) and 2015–2025 (filled, with values). Occupation codes harmonized across the 2002, 2010, and 2018 Census classification regimes. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

The appendix battery shows the portrait is not an artifact of specification. Across probit, weighted LPM, logit, state-and-year fixed effects, the full 1997–2024 window ( $n = 85,430$ ), and the occupation-pair definition of leaving, the job-attachment and birth coefficients never lose significance or change sign (Table 5). The subsample estimates (Table 6) add two findings worth text: a child under six *raises* women’s exit (+1.3) but *lowers* men’s (–2.2)—household specialization in one row—and pension coverage retains men more than twice as strongly as women (–4.5 versus –2.0).

## 10 Teaching among the professions

Is an eight percent outflow a lot? Figure 14 answers with the only benchmark that means anything: other professions, measured identically. Teaching sits in the middle of the college-professional range—above accountants and lawyers (5–6), essentially tied with nurses and physicians (8), far below social workers (14) and the therapy professions (11). Two things elevate the comparison beyond a ranking. First, teaching is the *only* profession in the figure whose leaving rate *fell* between the two windows (9.3 to 8.3); every other profession rose. Second, the comparison disciplines interpretation: whatever is pushing pharmacists and physical therapists up is economy-wide, not a crisis of schools. The annual series behind these windows are in Appendix Figure 17, and the same comparison estimated on Harris and Adams’s 1992–2001 window is in Appendix B—the ordering of professions is the same three decades later.

## 11 What the anatomy means for policy

This paper set out to measure, not to prescribe; but a measurement this long constrains prescriptions, and it is worth stating how.

*Retire the exodus frame.* Profession leaving is flat at its generation-long level, was flat through Covid within two years, and is lower today than in 2001. Policies premised on an accelerating outflow —emergency certification pipelines, across-the-board retention bonuses—address a trend that does not exist, and their evaluation against a mythical baseline will always look like success. The turnover problem American schools do have is distributional—by school, subject, and district (Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond, 2017; Hanushek et al., 2004)—and the CPS, which sees professions rather than schools, is the wrong lens for it; but a national policy sold on the national rate is answerable to the national rate.

*Aim at the margins that move.* The anatomy locates three. The retirement route (38 of every 100 leavers) responds to pension rules, and its mean age has already drifted from 61.3 to 65.2 across the window—policies that manage the timing of exits (phased retirement, return-to-work rules) operate on the largest single flow. The family route responds to the compatibility of teaching with an infant at home: the birth-year exit is twice nursing's, a third of it is a revolving door already, and the fading of the motherhood exit shows the margin is elastic to social change; job-protected paid leave and genuine part-time ladders are the obvious levers, and our underpowered but right-signed paid-leave interaction suggests the experiment is worth running properly. The early-career route (11 percent at ages 21–25, half of it to other jobs, disproportionately male and private-sector) is standard career search; the productive response is selection and early support, not universal retention spending on a flow that mostly self-corrects by age 30.

*Read the pay problem correctly.* Nothing here says pay does not matter; the point is where it matters. The exit rate cannot fall much—it is already anchored by routes pay does not touch—so the return to raising relative pay lies elsewhere: in who chooses to enter, in the quality margin of who stays, and in fairness to a workforce whose real median earnings have not grown in twenty years while every comparison profession's did. The pension result carries a specific warning: coverage retains (2.4 points, twice that for men), and coverage has fallen 14 points in two decades. Letting the deferred part of the compensation package erode while debating the current part is, on this evidence, exactly backwards.

*Treat teaching's turnover as the price of its accessibility.* The comparison figures reframe the profession's churn: teaching pays 66 cents on the college dollar, yet loses fewer of its members than social work, therapy, or (now) pharmacy, and uniquely improved across decades. Part of the reason is the same flexibility that shows up as the birth-year spike and the revolving door: teaching is cheap to leave *and cheap to re-enter*, which makes it the college profession most compatible with an interrupted life. A policy agenda that treated that accessibility as an asset to be organized—formal re-entry paths, leave that preserves attachment, part-time roles that are careers rather than exits—would work with the grain of the anatomy documented here.

The contribution of this paper is the anatomy itself: one instrument, twenty-eight consecutive years, every

exit routed, priced, and modeled. On that evidence, the American teaching profession is not hemorrhaging. It is aging, underpaid relative to its peers, uniquely exposed to the arithmetic of family life, and steady—losing its members to the same life events it has always lost them to, at the same rate, while the conversation about it swings with each news cycle. Policy should be built on the steadiness, not the swings.

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## A The instrument, audited

For respondents in CPS rotation groups that yield four consecutive monthly interviews after the reference year *and* a March retrospective response, profession leaving can be classified two independent ways: by the within-panel criterion (teaching occupation in all four post months versus none) and by the March retrospective question. Table 1 cross-tabulates the two for the pooled linked sample. Among panel-classified stayers, 96.8 percent are retrospective stayers; among panel-classified leavers, the March question recovers the exit or the non-teacher status in 99.2 percent of cases; overall agreement is 99.1 percent. The March instrument, in short, reproduces at the person level the classification a short panel would give—while covering four times the sample and every year since 1998.

**Table 1:** March retrospective vs. linked-panel classification.

| Linked-panel classification        | March retrospective classification |        |      |       |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------------|--------|------|-------|
|                                    | Not a teacher                      | Stayed | Left | Total |
| Stayer (teaches all 4 post months) | 198                                | 7,911  | 67   | 8,176 |
| Leaver (teaches in none)           | 1,018                              | 10     | 257  | 1,285 |
| Total                              | 1,216                              | 7,921  | 324  | 9,461 |

Pooled linked sample, survey years 2011–2024. Rows: 4-month within-panel classification; columns: March retrospective classification. Source: author’s calculations from CPS basic monthly files and March supplements.

## B Comparison with Harris and Adams (2007)

Harris and Adams pooled the March supplements of survey years 1992–2001 and reported route-decomposed leaving for teachers, nurses, social workers, and accountants. Table 2 reproduces their estimates alongside ours for 2015–2024, constructed identically. Levels are within 1.5 points for every profession, the ordering is unchanged after a quarter century, and the route structure—teachers leaving mostly to non-employment, social workers mostly to other jobs—is intact. The stability of this comparison across thirty years and two occupational classification systems is itself a finding: the relative anatomy of professional turnover is a slow-moving object.

**Table 2:** Leaving rates and routes: 1992–2001 vs. 2015–2024.

|                | Harris & Adams, 1992–2001 |        |        |        | This paper, 2015–2024 |        |        |        |
|----------------|---------------------------|--------|--------|--------|-----------------------|--------|--------|--------|
|                | All                       | Switch | Unemp. | Out LF | All                   | Switch | Unemp. | Out LF |
| Teachers       | 7.73                      | 2.59   | 0.61   | 4.53   | 8.25                  | 2.12   | 1.00   | 5.12   |
| Nurses         | 6.09                      | 1.68   | 0.86   | 3.54   | 7.66                  | 3.31   | 0.80   | 3.54   |
| Social workers | 14.94                     | 10.87  | 1.34   | 2.73   | 13.55                 | 9.45   | 1.22   | 2.89   |
| Accountants    | 8.01                      | 4.10   | 1.55   | 2.36   | 6.30                  | 1.79   | 1.18   | 3.32   |

Left block: Harris and Adams (2007), Table 1, March CPS 1992–2001. Right block: author’s calculations, identical definitions, March CPS 2015–2024 (survey years 2016–2025). All rates in percent per year.

## C Data construction

**Sources.** Survey years 2011–2025: Census machine-readable ASEC person files. Survey years 1998–2010: the original fixed-width public-use files, parsed at the byte positions published in the official technical documentation (`cpsmarYY.pdf`); positions are constant within the 1998–2002 and 2003–2010 layout eras. Household-level variables (state of residence) are read from the household records and merged on the household sequence number. Every extraction is validated with sanity gates (age distributions, weight positivity, education recode ranges, teacher shares of occupation) that abort rather than ship on failure.

**Table 3:** Record counts by source.

| Source                              | Survey years | Persons   | Teacher-years | Teacher-years<br>(BA+, 18+) |
|-------------------------------------|--------------|-----------|---------------|-----------------------------|
| Machine-readable ASEC files         | 2011–2025    | 2,585,797 | 54,620        | 45,296                      |
| Fixed-width files, official layouts | 1998–2010    | 2,423,332 | 49,925        | 40,201                      |
| Total                               | 1998–2025    | 5,009,129 | 104,545       | 85,497                      |

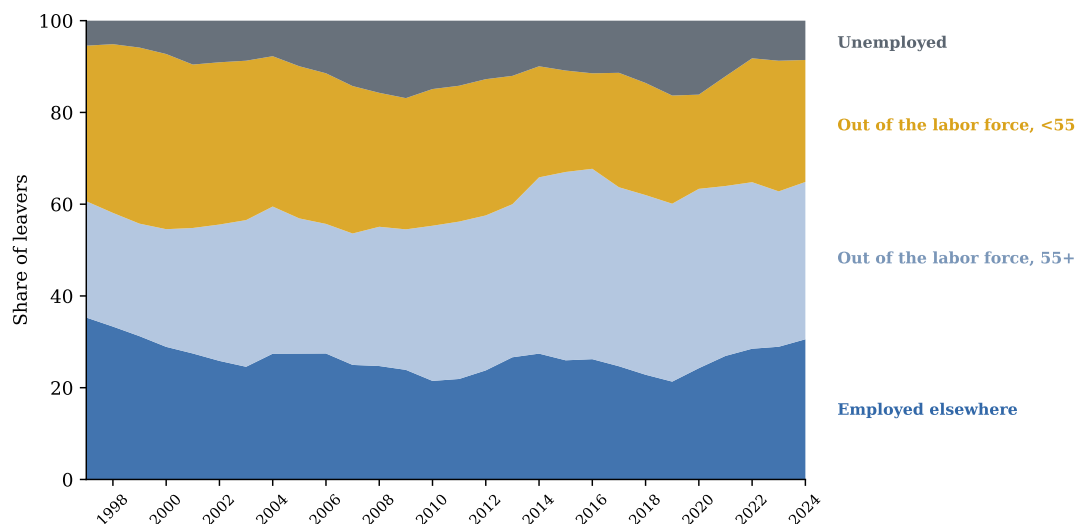
Teacher-years: longest job last year in a K–12 teaching occupation. The baseline analysis universe is college-graduate teachers aged 18+. Calendar-year coverage is 1997–2024.

**Occupation codes.** K–12 teaching is defined as codes 155–159 (1990 classification; surveys through 2002), 2300–2340 (2002 and 2010 classifications), and 2300–2330 plus 2360 (2018 classification; surveys from 2020), excluding postsecondary teachers, aides, and tutors. A core-codes-only series (excluding the “other teachers” residual in all years) shows the same level and profile. Comparison professions use analogously era-consistent sets.

**External series.** National unemployment: BLS via FRED (UNRATE); state unemployment: BLS Local Area Unemployment Statistics via FRED, March values of the survey year; deflator: CPI-U annual averages via FRED, base 2024. All cached with their sources in the replication package.

## D Additional figures

## E Appendix tables



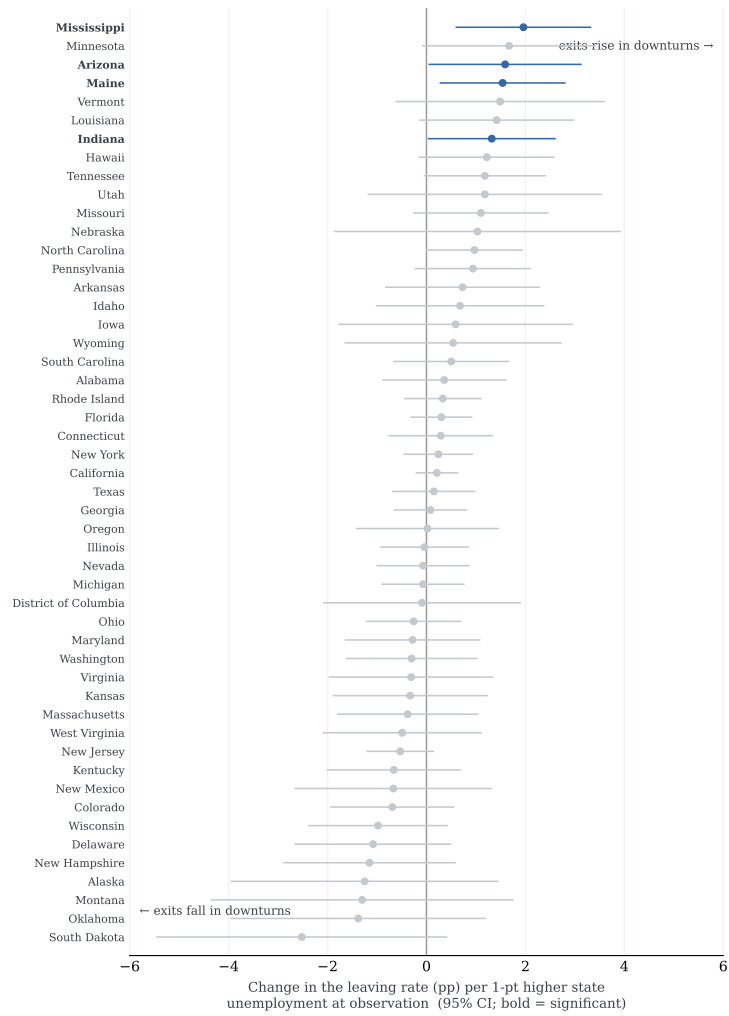
**Figure 15:** Route composition of leavers, 1997–2024.

Shares of college-graduate leavers by route (3-year averages, renormalized to 100). The retirement-age share rises from roughly a quarter to nearly forty percent; the young out-of-labor-force (family) share falls symmetrically. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.

**Table 4:** Sample balance: teachers and other college graduates, 2015–2024.

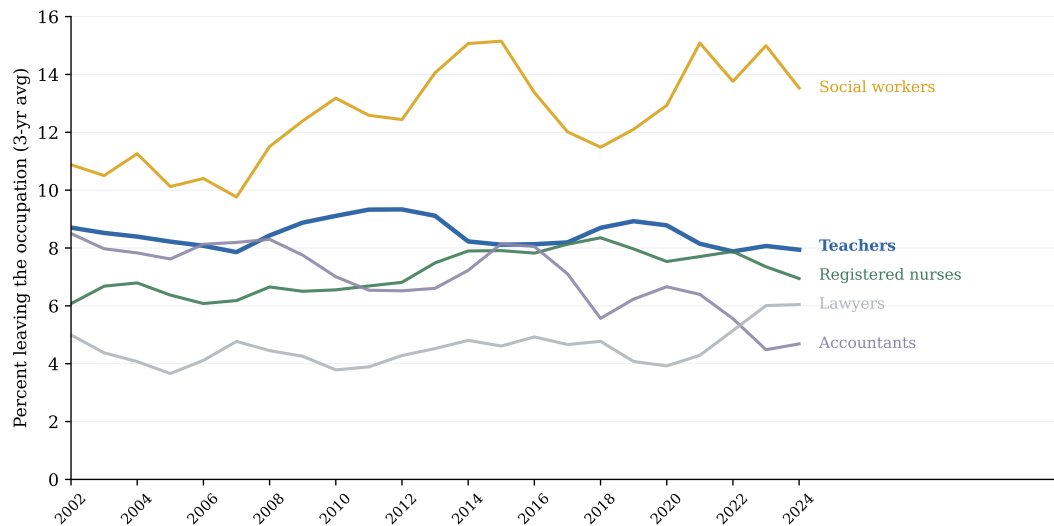
|                               | Teachers, women | Teachers, men | All teachers | Other college workers |
|-------------------------------|-----------------|---------------|--------------|-----------------------|
| <i>Demographics</i>           |                 |               |              |                       |
| Age (years)                   | 44.2 (12.8)     | 44.9 (13.3)   | 44.3 (12.9)  | 44.1 (13.6)           |
| Female                        | 100.0           | 0.0           | 76.0         | 48.7                  |
| Black                         | 9.6             | 9.5           | 9.6          | 9.6                   |
| Married                       | 66.6            | 67.7          | 66.9         | 62.6                  |
| Child under 6                 | 16.1            | 17.2          | 16.4         | 15.0                  |
| Number of children            | 0.8 (1.1)       | 0.8 (1.1)     | 0.8 (1.1)    | 0.6 (1.0)             |
| <i>Education</i>              |                 |               |              |                       |
| Master’s degree or higher     | 51.3            | 53.6          | 51.9         | 35.4                  |
| <i>Job held last year</i>     |                 |               |              |                       |
| Government employer           | 70.3            | 70.4          | 70.3         | 15.5                  |
| Part-time (<35 h/wk)          | 15.2            | 11.4          | 14.3         | 13.5                  |
| Full year (50+ weeks)         | 71.1            | 74.8          | 72.0         | 85.0                  |
| Pension plan at work          | 66.4            | 67.3          | 66.6         | 46.1                  |
| Wage earnings, median (\$)    | 50,000          | 58,000        | 52,000       | 70,000                |
| <i>Transitions</i>            |                 |               |              |                       |
| Leaves teaching within a year | 7.9             | 9.1           | 8.2          | –                     |
| Person-years (unweighted N)   | 22,097          | 6,785         | 28,882       | 277,364               |

Weighted means; standard deviations in parentheses for continuous variables. Wage earnings are medians, current dollars, conditional on positive earnings. “Leaves teaching” is undefined for non-teachers. Source: author’s calculations from March CPS supplements.



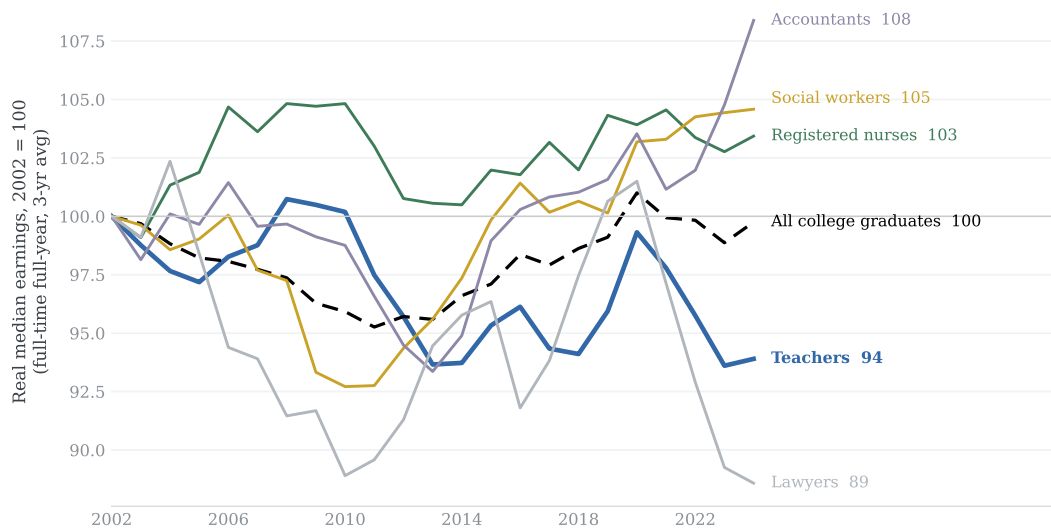
**Figure 16:** State-level cyclicalities of leaving: all 51 jurisdictions.

Slope of a weighted linear probability model of leaving on the state unemployment rate in the survey month, estimated separately by state on all years 1997–2024; 95 percent intervals, heteroskedasticity-robust. Bold: significant at 5 percent. Source: author's calculations from March CPS supplements and BLS LAUS.



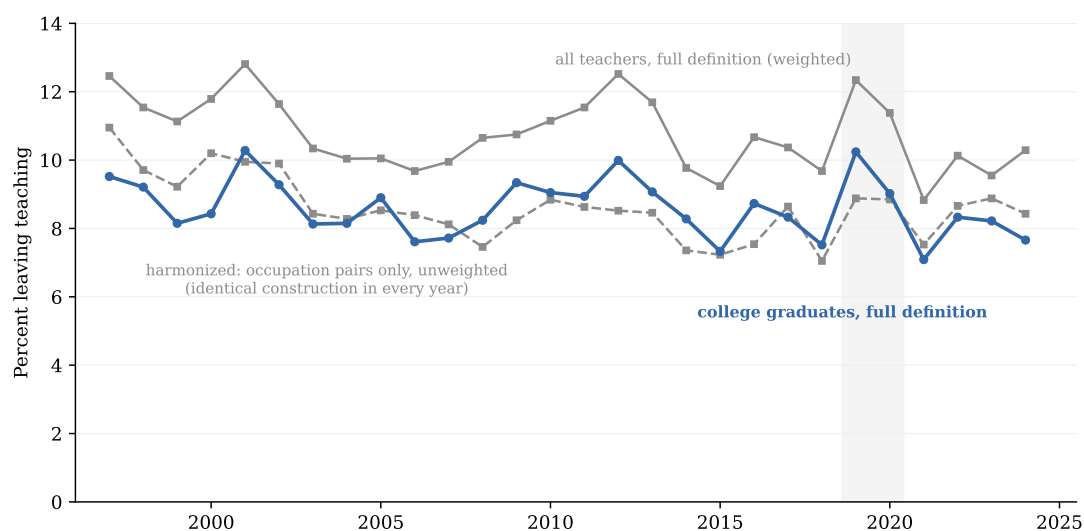
**Figure 17:** Occupational leaving in five professions, annual series.

Three-year averages of the annual occupational leaving rate, college graduates, identical definitions across professions; the window figures of the main text pool these series. Source: author's calculations from March CPS supplements, survey years 2003–2025.



**Figure 18:** Real median pay by profession, indexed.

Real median annual earnings of full-time full-year college graduates aged 25–60 by profession, CPI-U deflated, indexed to 2002 = 100, 3-year averages; endpoint values printed. Source: author's calculations from March CPS supplements.



**Figure 19:** The leaving series under alternative definitions.

The baseline route-based college-graduate series alongside the all-education series and the harmonized occupation-pair-only construction. Levels differ by universe; profiles coincide. Source: author's calculations from March CPS supplements.

**Table 5:** Robustness of the attrition model.

|                            | (1)<br>Probit      | (2)<br>LPM, wtd.    | (3)<br>Logit       | (4)<br>LPM, FE      | (5)<br>Probit, full | (6)<br>LPM, pair   |
|----------------------------|--------------------|---------------------|--------------------|---------------------|---------------------|--------------------|
| Age (years)                | -0.80***<br>(0.08) | -1.40***<br>(0.13)  | -0.68***<br>(0.07) | -1.38***<br>(0.13)  | -0.83***<br>(0.05)  | -1.28***<br>(0.13) |
| Age <sup>2</sup> /100      | 0.96***<br>(0.08)  | 1.71***<br>(0.15)   | 0.84***<br>(0.07)  | 1.69***<br>(0.15)   | 0.99***<br>(0.05)   | 1.53***<br>(0.14)  |
| Female                     | -1.42***<br>(0.34) | -1.68***<br>(0.45)  | -1.35***<br>(0.34) | -1.61***<br>(0.45)  | -1.34***<br>(0.21)  | -1.49***<br>(0.42) |
| Black                      | 1.86***<br>(0.49)  | 2.22***<br>(0.69)   | 1.77***<br>(0.49)  | 2.39***<br>(0.72)   | 2.10***<br>(0.31)   | 1.44**<br>(0.63)   |
| Married                    | -0.23<br>(0.47)    | 0.49<br>(0.58)      | -0.23<br>(0.49)    | 0.47<br>(0.59)      | -0.32<br>(0.29)     | 0.46<br>(0.54)     |
| Separated/divorced/widowed | 0.96<br>(0.59)     | 1.78**<br>(0.78)    | 0.97<br>(0.59)     | 1.73**<br>(0.78)    | 0.29<br>(0.36)      | 1.56**<br>(0.73)   |
| Master's degree or higher  | -0.84***<br>(0.30) | -0.50<br>(0.38)     | -0.85***<br>(0.30) | -0.45<br>(0.40)     | -0.58***<br>(0.18)  | -0.59*<br>(0.35)   |
| Public school              | -1.74***<br>(0.32) | -1.56***<br>(0.47)  | -1.64***<br>(0.32) | -1.59***<br>(0.48)  | -1.28***<br>(0.20)  | -1.24***<br>(0.44) |
| Pension plan at work       | -2.46***<br>(0.32) | -2.57***<br>(0.45)  | -2.47***<br>(0.32) | -2.56***<br>(0.45)  | -3.11***<br>(0.20)  | -2.08***<br>(0.42) |
| Part-time (<35 h/wk)       | 4.37***<br>(0.37)  | 8.25***<br>(0.85)   | 3.95***<br>(0.35)  | 8.22***<br>(0.85)   | 4.62***<br>(0.22)   | 6.82***<br>(0.79)  |
| Worked full year (50+ wks) | -9.26***<br>(0.32) | -12.47***<br>(0.54) | -9.66***<br>(0.33) | -12.55***<br>(0.54) | -10.32***<br>(0.19) | -9.77***<br>(0.49) |
| Number of children         | -0.47***<br>(0.17) | -0.38*<br>(0.20)    | -0.65***<br>(0.18) | -0.37*<br>(0.20)    | -0.72***<br>(0.11)  | -0.33*<br>(0.18)   |
| Child under 6              | 0.45<br>(0.51)     | 0.50<br>(0.50)      | 0.52<br>(0.54)     | 0.54<br>(0.51)      | 0.62**<br>(0.30)    | 0.67<br>(0.47)     |
| New baby this year         | 4.61***<br>(0.78)  | 5.42***<br>(1.23)   | 4.85***<br>(0.77)  | 5.44***<br>(1.23)   | 4.76***<br>(0.43)   | 4.78***<br>(1.17)  |
| Observations               | 28,900             | 28,900              | 28,900             | 28,900              | 85,430              | 28,900             |

Dependent variable: leaving teaching (percentage points). Column (1): baseline probit AMEs, 2015–2024, year effects, unweighted. (2): weighted linear probability model, HC1. (3): logit AMEs. (4): weighted LPM with state and year effects. (5): probit on the full 1997–2024 window. (6): weighted LPM with the occupation-pair definition of leaving. Standard errors in parentheses; \*, \*\*, \*\*\* denote 10, 5, and 1 percent.

**Table 6:** The attrition model in subsamples.

|                            | Women               | Men                 | Public              | Private             | Under 45           | 45+                 |
|----------------------------|---------------------|---------------------|---------------------|---------------------|--------------------|---------------------|
| Age (years)                | -1.35***<br>(0.15)  | -1.41***<br>(0.28)  | -1.38***<br>(0.16)  | -1.44***<br>(0.25)  | -0.00<br>(0.51)    | -1.31**<br>(0.59)   |
| Age <sup>2</sup> /100      | 1.66***<br>(0.17)   | 1.69***<br>(0.30)   | 1.77***<br>(0.18)   | 1.61***<br>(0.26)   | -0.22<br>(0.73)    | 1.65***<br>(0.51)   |
| Female                     | —                   | —                   | -0.71<br>(0.48)     | -4.06***<br>(1.03)  | -1.20**<br>(0.59)  | -2.05***<br>(0.70)  |
| Black                      | 2.45***<br>(0.77)   | 1.20<br>(1.48)      | 2.01***<br>(0.75)   | 2.41<br>(1.47)      | 3.19***<br>(1.00)  | 0.74<br>(0.91)      |
| Married                    | 0.18<br>(0.66)      | 1.72<br>(1.23)      | 0.81<br>(0.64)      | -0.07<br>(1.24)     | 0.62<br>(0.70)     | -0.29<br>(1.05)     |
| Separated/divorced/widowed | 1.43<br>(0.88)      | 2.94*<br>(1.76)     | 2.25**<br>(0.88)    | 0.46<br>(1.58)      | 1.34<br>(1.05)     | 1.07<br>(1.21)      |
| Master's degree or higher  | -0.28<br>(0.43)     | -1.51*<br>(0.83)    | -0.53<br>(0.41)     | -0.48<br>(0.81)     | -1.37***<br>(0.48) | 0.13<br>(0.59)      |
| Public school              | -1.12**<br>(0.53)   | -3.11***<br>(1.04)  | —                   | —                   | -3.53***<br>(0.60) | 0.61<br>(0.74)      |
| Pension plan at work       | -1.95***<br>(0.50)  | -4.54***<br>(1.01)  | -2.99***<br>(0.54)  | -2.03**<br>(0.80)   | -2.50***<br>(0.56) | -2.74***<br>(0.71)  |
| Part-time (<35 h/wk)       | 7.86***<br>(0.93)   | 10.63***<br>(2.07)  | 10.96***<br>(1.21)  | 5.37***<br>(1.21)   | 7.96***<br>(1.17)  | 7.68***<br>(1.20)   |
| Worked full year (50+ wks) | -12.35***<br>(0.60) | -13.01***<br>(1.20) | -10.33***<br>(0.59) | -16.85***<br>(1.11) | -8.29***<br>(0.69) | -16.89***<br>(0.82) |
| Number of children         | -0.46**<br>(0.23)   | 0.03<br>(0.39)      | -0.10<br>(0.22)     | -0.92**<br>(0.42)   | -0.41<br>(0.26)    | -0.52<br>(0.33)     |
| Child under 6              | 1.30**<br>(0.59)    | -2.22**<br>(0.97)   | 0.97*<br>(0.52)     | -0.35<br>(1.19)     | -0.07<br>(0.59)    | -1.28<br>(1.46)     |
| New baby this year         | 5.67***<br>(1.49)   | 5.22**<br>(2.17)    | 4.69***<br>(1.30)   | 6.51**<br>(2.73)    | 5.54***<br>(1.25)  | 13.64<br>(9.34)     |
| Observations               | 22,114              | 6,786               | 20,648              | 8,252               | 15,384             | 13,516              |

Weighted linear probability models with year effects, 2015–2024, HC1 standard errors in parentheses; “—” marks regressors without variation in the subsample. \*, \*\*, \*\*\* denote 10, 5, and 1 percent.

**Table 7:** Paid family leave and the birth-year exit.

|                          | Coefficient (pp) | SE     | <i>p</i> |
|--------------------------|------------------|--------|----------|
| New baby                 | +6.60            | (1.19) | 0.000    |
| Paid family leave active | +0.47            | (0.35) | 0.181    |
| New baby × paid leave    | −2.10            | (2.24) | 0.349    |

Weighted LPM of leaving on a new-baby indicator interacted with an indicator for the state having an active paid family leave program (first full benefit years: CA 2005, NJ 2010, RI 2014, NY 2018, WA 2020, DC/MA 2021, CT 2022, OR 2024), with state and year effects and demographic controls; standard errors clustered by state.  $n = 77,883$  teacher-years; 268 births under active programs. The interaction is right-signed and uninformative: the design awaits more treated cohorts.